



The Grassroots Revolution

Your experts are already ahead.

Your job is to see them, grow them, and let them spread.

Magnus Udbjørg · CTO, TestaViva

A quick intro

Magnus Udbjørg

CTO at TestaViva. Lead a cross-functional engineering organization — platform, data, DevOps, product.

My work sits where software delivery, operational effectiveness, and expert judgment meet.

TestaViva

Danish legal-tech company. Helps people create legal documents and get legal guidance digitally.

Founded 2016 · Copenhagen · Family & inheritance, housing, business, estate administration.

**In our world, AI only creates value if it improves work without eroding trust.
That's what makes AI adoption a leadership problem, not a tooling debate.**

AI adoption is everywhere. The pressure is real.

Every leader in this room feels it — from boards, from competitors, from their own teams.

90%

of engineering teams
now use AI tools

Jellyfish 2025

53%

of leaders say
productivity must increase

Microsoft WTI

80%

of workforce lack
time or energy

Microsoft WTI

**Adoption is not the problem. Everyone has adopted.
The problem is what comes next.**

More AI adoption does not mean better outcomes

+20%

PRs per author
with AI tools

+23.5%

incidents per
pull request

+30%

change failure
rate

Cortex 2026 Engineering in the Age of AI Report

56%

of CEOs report getting "nothing" from
AI adoption efforts — PwC 2026

95%

of gen AI pilots fail to move
beyond experimental — MIT

Teams are moving faster — and breaking more things.

When leaders say "use AI" without saying what good looks like

Mandate + pressure = workslop — AI output that looks finished but shifts the real thinking onto someone else.

40%

received workslop
last month

42%

saw the sender as
less trustworthy

\$9M+

annual cost per
10k employees

"Workslop is a management failure." — Kate Niederhoffer, BetterUp

So: pressure is real, adoption is everywhere, and it's producing slop, not quality.
What actually produces quality?

The DORA 2025 Report answered this:

**AI doesn't fix a team.
It amplifies what's
already there.**

**Strong teams get stronger.
Struggling teams crack under pressure.**

Which means your strategy isn't about adoption.
It's about the people AI amplifies.

Your experts are already there

In every team, 1–2 people have built intuition. Their colleagues learn by watching.

Contextual

Same codebase, same trade-offs

Trusted

A peer, not a vendor or mandate

Continuous

Standups, reviews, Slack, pairing

Pull-based

Learn when ready to solve a real problem

Toyota gave AI/ML tools to ~1,200 factory workers. They created 10,000 models and saved 10,000+ hours. The people closest to the work found the value.

DORA confirms: the value comes not from tools, but from the practices and cultural environment around them. Your experts ARE that environment.

What makes your experts different — and how you multiply them

Pilot mindset

Owens the output · Edits aggressively
Knows when AI helps · Judges quality

Passenger mindset

Prompts once · Accepts first draft
Forwards without judgment · Optimizes for volume

3.6×

more productive

3.1×

more likely to stay

~3×

team multiplier when
manager models it

People become pilots through practice, feedback, and watching someone who already has it. When YOU model it, your team follows 3× faster.

Your role as a leader

Be the amplifier, not the controller.

1

See who gets asked AI questions — that's your expert

2

Give them time and air cover to experiment

3

Use AI visibly yourself — say "let me Claude Code that one" in front of the team

4

Share your own failed experiments openly

5

Connect experts across teams — don't let them stay pocketed

These are tiny moves. That is why they scale.

06

NURTURE THEM

Five daily behaviors + three guardrails

01

Ask for data first

"What does the data say?" replaces "I think..."

02

Start from customer pain

AI experiments should solve real problems, not demo tools.

03

Pair across functions

Connect AI-fluent engineers with domain experts.

04

Make learning visible

"What AI thing did you try this week?"
Celebrate failures.

05

**Give permission to
rethink**

"Could AI change how we do this?" should
feel safe to ask.

Three guardrails

1

Protect data

No customer data in unvetted services

2

Pilot before scale

Test on real work before broad rollout

3

Share what you learn

Knowledge hoarding is the only anti-pattern

Trust is the #1 predictor of reducing workstop. Guardrails create the safety for experts to thrive — and for everyone else to start learning from them.

Replace these instincts

Mandate AI use + expect more output

→ **Set quality bars — define what good looks like**

Standardize one tool for everyone

→ **Standardize guardrails — let people pick tools**

Train everyone in a classroom

→ **Enable peer pairing on real work**

Approve every use case via committee

→ **Run small pilots and report back**

Measure adoption rate

→ **Measure speed, quality, and customer impact**

When you measure adoption, people optimize the metric.

When you measure outcomes, people optimize the work.

A 90-day plan

Do not scale a program. Nurture a movement.

1



2



3



4

Weeks 1–2

See

Who are your experts?
What are they already doing?
Who do people go to?

Weeks 3–4

Connect

Bring them together informally.
Ask: What's working?
What would you do with more time?

Month 2

Grow

Create one ritual: bi-weekly
30-min experiment sharing.
Celebrate useful failures.

Month 3+

Spread

Pair experts with non-adopters
on real work (not training).
Measure outcomes, not usage.

See → Connect → Grow → Spread

No mandatory training sessions required.

A final thought on why this matters

Hartmut Rosa's warning

Being a human agent used to mean finding yourself in situations requiring discretion, judgment, and sensitivity based on experience.

But more and more activities now require only the execution of rules, algorithms, and instructions. When the scope for discretion is eliminated, agency atrophies.

Discretion
replaced by rules



Agency
atrophies



**Self-world relation
breaks (alienation)**

Rosa's antidote: resonance — a relationship with the world where we are affected by it, and where our judgment and actions still matter.

Automating judgment doesn't just change how we work — it hollows out agency itself. That hollowing is what burns people out.

This is the pilot vs. passenger choice

Passenger

Prompt → accept → send.
Discretion delegated to the LLM.
Agency atrophies. Alienation.
Workslop is the artifact.

Pilot

Use AI, but own the judgment.
Discretion preserved. Agency intact.
Resonance with your craft.
Quality is the artifact.

The grassroots are already growing. Water them.

See them. Grow them. Let them spread.

The leader's job is not to be the expert.

It is to make the experts visible, connected, and empowered
— and to protect their agency.

Q & A

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